

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

When Things Fall Apart ~ Heart Advice for Difficult Times
The Love That Will Not Die
August 24th, 2025



Sunset Boats on the Shore, 1910
Trush Ivan Ivanovych
Ukraine

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The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Improvisation on GIFT OF LOVE and NICAEA
German Folk Song Arrangement (Christoph Bull)
Ecclusiastics (Charles Mingus, arr. C. Bull)
Trio ALLES WAS DU BIST (Billy Nalle)
Chorale Prelude ROSEA PANTHERA (Improvisation)
Chorale Prelude IN DIR IST FREUDE / IN THEE IS GLADNESS (Johannes Michel)

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Michael Lehman

Words of Gathering

Rev. Lehman, Lance & Brittany Skiles

Holy One, as we gather each week,
we give thanks for the opportunity
to see the world through your eyes
and know once again,
that we are always and forever
held by your love.

When the sun shines,
and when the rain falls,
we are held by your love.

When the money gods smile upon us,
and when the bottom falls out of the market,
we are held by your love.

When family is the wind beneath our wings,
and when it is a hurricane of hurt,
we are held by your love.

When we are strong in body and mind,
and when illness reveals our vulnerability,
we are held by your love.

When the beauty of creation drops us to our knees in awe,
and when the injustice of humanity drops us to
our knees in prayer,
we are held by your love.

For we, O God, are in you,
and you are in us,
and there is a country of the soul

where the eternal joy of Being
sustains us on the rocky road of becoming.

*This morning, Holy One,
we give thanks for your
never ending love
as we gather in this time
that is holy.*

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Please stand as you are able, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

Love Now Ascending

NICAEA

Holy, holy, holy, love now ascending
Early in the morning our song shall rise to you.
Holy, holy, holy, joy that has no ending
Giving, forgiving, breathing life anew.

Holy, holy, holy, love without a limit
Care that binds creation in sacred unity,
Holy, holy, holy, birthing every minute,
Christ, Love's revealer, sets our spirits free.

Holy, holy, holy, infinite compassion,
Makes a place for every soul in God's eternal reign,
Holy, holy, holy, truth beyond religion,
Love that endures should nothing else remain.

Holy, holy, holy, raise your voice in singing,
Join the cosmic chorus in praise of Love divine,
Holy, holy, holy, God beyond all naming,
Echoes our song in harmony sublime. [JBurklo]

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Lehman

All things come from you, O God,
and to you we return.
All things emerge in your great river of life
and into you we vanish again.

At the beginning of this day we wake
not as separate streams
but as countless currents in a single flow
the flow of this day's dawning
the flow of this day's delight
the flow of this day's sorrows
your flow, O God,
in the twistings and turnings of our days.
[jphilipnewell]

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!
Amen and Amen.

***Introit**

“Unclouded Day”
Laude

J.K. ALWOOD, arr. SHAWN KIRCHNER

***The Lord’s Prayer**

Brittany Skiles

The ‘Abba’ Prayer

*You are invited to pray in the spirit of the Lord’s Prayer, and in your original language,
as appropriate*

*Loving Presence, luminous in all creation,
hallowed be your name.
Thy kin-dom come.
May we reflect on earth
the yielding perfection of the heavens.*

*Help us to receive an illumed measure from the earth this day.
Forgive us when we trespass against others,
human and other than human,
as we forgive others who trespass against us.*

*Keep us on the path of wisdom
when we are tempted to take the selfish path.*

*May it be your rule we follow,
your power we exercise,
and your radiance that allures.*

*May this be the truth that guides our lives,
the ground from which our future will grow,
until we meet again.* (BSanguin/dddc)
Amen and Amen!

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Chad Tanaka Pack

With gratitude we have gathered in this place of peace, once again.
In this time together, may we continue to create here a circle of love,
ever expanding, ever growing.
A place of wisdom.
A place of connection.
A place of hope.

This morning, may the Peace and Love of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow.

Please be seated

Reading from Our Religious Tradition

A Reading from the Epistles - Compiled from 1 John 3-4

Lance & Brittany Skiles

Response to the Reading from Scripture

That wisdom was born with me in the womb

thanks be to you, O God.

That your ways have been written into

the human body and soul

there to be read and revered

thanks be to you.

Let me be attentive

to the truths of these living texts.

Let me learn

of the law etched into the whole of creation

that gave birth to the mystery of life

and feed and renews it day by day.

Let me discern the law of love in my own heart

and in knowing it

obey it.

Let me be set free by love, O God.

Let me be set free to love, O God. -J. Philip Newell

This is the Gospel of Grace.

Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Lehman

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

Lance & Brittany Skiles

Beloved One,

You created us in your image,

Divine Life within.

Equipped for healing,

You make us capable of right-ing relationships.

To history. To each other. To the planet. To our futures.

You wove courage into our bones,

and the want for each other into our flesh.

We can feel it when we are in-touch with life:

We need each other.

Make all that betrays this Sacred connection –
the everyday and the ordinary practices,
and the rising terror of evil's gains –
be exposed for what they are.
Deception. Poison. A breach of divine entanglement.
Through they dwell deep within us,
help us pluck them up from the roots.

Search our hearts.
Come with your winnowing fork
and separate out truth from falsehood.
Companion us in the work to clear away
that which destroys from within
and enables destruction around.
Deliver us from the confines of Supremacy in all its forms
and set us onto paths of freedom.

May our labors toward liberation be fruitful.
May we mean what we pray.
May we be compelled by dreams of collective transformation
to rise to the moment but also
to remain committed to mundane labors of long-term, systematic change.

May our loyalties to Love
rise above all others,
that we may no longer tolerate
our complicity with all that damages and destroys.

Made in your image,
we are made capable
of abolishing what is evil
and building a better world.
Make is so among us.
[enfleshed]

Amen and Amen!

Meditation Anthem	<i>"The Innocence" from Considering Matthew Shepherd</i> Rohan Ramanan, Soloist	CRAIG HELLA JOHNSON
Sermon	<i>The Love That Will Not Die</i>	Rev. Tanaka Pack
The Eucharist and Blessings		Rev. Lehman & Rev. Tanaka Pack

Words of Invitation and Remembrance
With our eyes wide open, we come to this table
knowing the realities of our world.

We live in a time and place
where words are honed to have painful edges,
where fear too often reigns,

and shards of broken trust are used as weapons,
rending into tatters relationships once built on love.

And yet, in this too-fragile world,
we look for ways to strengthen love
in all our relationships,
to live in ways that lift each other's souls,
and build, for every single human being,
a place that we might all know
the beauty of being celebrated for who they are.

*At this table we break bread, share stories, build new and
hope-filled memories as we let go of the hurts and heartaches
of other times and other tables.*

At this table we fill ourselves up with the things of love
that we might live strong and confident
in the places we hold in this world.

*As those who hold a vision of a love-filled world,
we break this bread as Jesus did,
and we eat together knowing it is the bread of new life.*

We also pour and share a cup as Jesus did,
because we want others to come and drink
this cup of hope along with us.

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

Invitation to Generosity

Lance Skiles

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give.

Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

"Hallelujah"
Cathedral Choir

LEONARD COHEN, arr. MARK BRYMER

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Prayer of Offering**

Brittany Skiles

Gracious One,
On this day, we found ourselves once again,
longing to reach out and touch the sky,
and to be in a place
where we could be reminded of your love.

On this day, we wanted to offer our tears
and ask they be held deep within the heart of life,
knowing they represent the struggles
we all still endure.

On this day, we needed to be embraced
by loving arms telling us again and again,
that in this place, we are all welcome.

We give thanks, Holy One,
for the love and assurance we have been given
in this time together.
Help us now as we leave this place of amazing love,
to open our eyes to all that is around us
and truly see with the eyes of our hearts,
those who desperately need your love, and our love.

For this and so much more,
we ask, and we give thanks, O God.
Amen and Amen!

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Lehman & Rev. Tanaka Pack

Words of Blessing

Rev. Tanaka Pack

Love all Creation
The whole of it and every grain of sand
Love every leaf
Every ray of God's light
Love the animals
Love the plants
Love everything
If you love everything
You will perceive
The divine mystery in things
And once you have perceived it
You will begin to comprehend it ceaselessly
More and more everyday
And you will at last come to love the whole world
With an abiding universal love

-Fyodor Dostoyevsky

May it be so.
May it be so for us!

Choral Response

"Agnus Dei" from Mass In A Time Of War
Cathedral Choir

JOSEPH HAYDN

***Hymn for the Journey**

When Love Is Found

GIFT OF LOVE

When love is found and hope comes home,
Sing and be glad that two are one.
When love explodes and fills the sky,
Praise God, and share our Maker's joy.

When love has flowered in trust and care,
Build both each day, that love may dare
To reach beyond home's warmth and light,
To serve and strive for truth and right.

When love is tried as loved-ones change,
Hold still to hope, though all seems strange,
Till ease returns and love grows wise
Through listening ears and opened eyes.

When love is torn, and trust betrayed,
Pray strength to love till torments fade,
Till lovers keep no score of wrong,
But hear through pain love's Easter song.

Praise God for love, praise God for life,
In age or youth, in calm or strife.
Lift up your hearts! Let love be fed
Through death and life in broken bread.

Please be seated for the Postlude

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

IN DIR IST FREUDE / IN THEE IS GLADNESS - Reprise (Johannes Michel)

Inside The Music

"Both "Innocence" and "Hallelujah" share a clear-eyed determination to believe in life and love. I say clear-eyed, because they seem to sidestep hope as an answer to hardship. In "Considering Matthew Shepherd" Craig Hella Johnson creates a requiem for Matthew Shepherd as a patron saint of all marginalized individuals. Shepherd's brutal death and subsequent national reflection played a significant role in my understanding of compassion. He and I were the same age. I was in my early twenties, teaching high school in the south, and beginning to open my mind to the politics and personhood that surround identity. Shepherd's death shocked us into realizing that we all had to be vocal about the generations-long embedded hate that lay at the center of the crime. In "Innocence" Johnson reflects on this shock. In a folk-like setting reminiscent of English balladiers like Sting, he asks whether we can ever feel the freedom of innocence after experiencing something so damaging. The flood of challenges that flow like rain wash away even our ability to recall what freedom once felt like. The deeper question he asks, though, is whether humanity can ever become compassionate in ways that

allow people to live innocently. The idea of innocence aligns with how I understand unconditional love. I've known people who said they could never love unconditionally because they always know what others have done, and can't let it go. Their preconditions to love that protected them from hurt outweighed the value of loving first. I feel fortunate that I was taught that love simply is. Nothing can get in the way of love, no matter how hard. Johnson's music, in its lyric simplicity, sings this compassionate refrain to me. As the rain washes away the memories of innocence, we see more clearly what people can do to one another. Even in the face of this, though, the dreams, songs, joys, and laughter remain. Love, through the sadness, is still love. Our clear eyes see an enduring truth to being in love, rather than a hoped-for world without conflict. Cohen's "Hallelujah" is probably one of the most widely-known pieces in the world today. I have always been drawn to how much it says while saying very little. The poetry rolls from one lush image to another. We want to hold onto each word as if it were a secret to life. As they pass through our fingers, we're met with the refrain. Cohen's "hallelujah" isn't only the celebratory thing of religion past. It's complicated, it's whole. Every time we think we understand it, the meaning expands. When he finally arrives at love, it's a dark place. "Love is not a victory march" he tells us "it's a cold, and it's a broken hallelujah." Love, the hoped for, singsong kind of love with its hearts and roses, can't withstand the pressures of life. But love broken open into its unconditional, compassionate core, is "hallelujah" in all its fullness. In both of these pieces, the music and word repetition holds place for that which we don't know how to say, but want to feel. They avoid the sugary coating of hope and promise. They bring us into being with love. They remind us that we can exist deeply, affirmatively whole to ourselves and our communities even in the face of hardship, because love is the divine, never-ceasing core of life." – Dr. David Harris